



Photographs by GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times
MIGRANT laborers with Fresh Harvest, which provides housing for H-2A workers, head out to harvest romaine lettuce in Salinas. Some advocates say the H-2A program is an injustice to longtime farmworkers.

A delicate work-life balance inside America’s ‘salad bowl’

SALINAS, Calif. — Every year, farmers in this fertile valley dubbed the “salad bowl of the world” rely on tens of thousands of workers to harvest leafy greens and juicy strawberries. But with local farmworkers aging — and the Trump administration’s determined crackdown on the illegal workers who have long been the backbone of California’s agricultural workforce — more growers have been looking to legal channels to import foreign workers.

Under the federal H-2A visa program, agricultural employers can hire workers from other countries on a temporary basis, so long as they show that they were unable to hire sufficient numbers of domestic workers. Employers are required to provide the guest workers with housing, food and transportation.

But in Monterey County, one of the more expensive regions in the nation, the obligation to provide an exploding number

In Monterey County, farmers invest in housing for guest laborers. Migrants without visas are out of luck.

By Melissa Gomez and Rebecca Plevin



ISRAEL FRANCISCO, with sons Gael and Elias, is a longtime farmworker in Monterey County.

of guest workers with suitable housing was exacerbating a regional affordable housing crisis. Growers and labor contractors were buying up single-family homes and motels — often the residence of last resort for people on the verge of homelessness — making housing even more scarce for low-wage workers living in the region year-round.

For some large farming companies in the county, the solution has been to privately fund the construction of new housing facilities for H-2A workers. Since 2015, local growers have invested their own capital and often their own land to build at least eight housing complexes for thousands of guest workers.

These are not akin to the crude barracks used to house the Mexican guest workers known as *braceros* decades ago, nor are they the broken-down trailers associated with

[See *Guest workers*, A12]

Many Trump policies align closely with Project 2025

On the campaign trail, president had tried to distance himself from the ultraconservative plan for governing.

By KEVIN RECTOR

In his Project 2025 chapter on trade, economist Peter Navarro called on the next U.S. president to bring about a domestic manufacturing “renaissance” by adopting reciprocal tariffs against trading partners and taking a particularly hard line on China.

Promptly after being elected, President Trump appointed Navarro as his senior counselor for trade and manufacturing. Within months, he announced sweeping new tariffs largely in line with Navarro’s sug-

gestions.

When the stock market plunged and economists warned of increasing inflation and a potential recession, several of Trump’s other advisors rushed to step in, drive space between him and Navarro and prod the president into hitting pause on much of the plan.

The episode, which sent shock waves through the global economy, illustrated a broader pattern in which the president has rushed to implement unconventional or extreme policies also outlined in Project 2025.

He has done so despite having insisted throughout his 2024 presidential campaign that he wanted nothing to do with the unpopular, ultraconservative playbook, and despite warnings from experts and other liberal critics that such policies were unwise, if not illegal.

[See *Project 2025*, A9]

Residents fed up with illegal waste

In Antelope Valley, lawsuits allege that thousands of tons of trash were unlawfully dumped.

By SUSANNE RUST

Eric Eller likes to ride his dirt bikes through the canyons, dry riverbeds and rocky outcroppings of the Antelope Valley in the high desert north of Los Angeles.

Eller’s an off-the-grid kind of guy with a “Mad Max” vibe — living in a house on a remote plot of land next to a jury-rigged trailer where he tinkers with the remnants and pieces of gutted

automobiles, motorcycles and other mechanical debris.

But Eller’s isolation was obliterated last June when dozens of big dump trucks began snaking up the dirt road behind his house and discarding their loads into the nearby dry river canyon. The caravan of waste-haulers continued in the days that followed, often arriving after sundown or in the dark hours before dawn.

Two months later, the convoys abruptly stopped. But not before the makeshift dump’s surface had been camouflaged with dirt and mulch — much of which has since blown away, revealing a 30-foot-deep noxious stew of chopped-up concrete,

[See *Dumping*, A11]

COLUMN ONE

‘The Mummy’ is a lifestyle rather than a movie for this big fan

For Evan Halleck, 330 VHS copies of the 1999 film starring Brendan Fraser just don’t cut it. So he’s hitting the road to find more.

By JESSIE SCHIEWE

It’s probably safe to say there’s only one person in the world who would spend a Wednesday morning sitting barefoot in the sand watching Rick O’Connell search for the ancient lost city of Hamunaptra on a TV/VCR combo at the beach. And that person is Evan Halleck.

A 34-year-old former commercial editor and VFX artist who worked on “Everything Everywhere All at Once,” Halleck is an industry name you’ve probably never heard of, but those who spend a lot of time online might recognize his social media pseudonym: @MummyManiac.

Feeling creatively stifled, Halleck quit his full-time job last summer to pursue his goal of amassing the largest collection of “The Mummy” on VHS. The 1999 film starring Brendan Fraser has been one of Halleck’s favorite

[See *‘The Mummy,’* A14]



ALICIA VERA For The Times

A SINGER performs at Guitarrazos, an event that featured narcocorridos, songs that recount and often glamorize the spoils and perils of drug cartel life in Mexico.

A ban on ballads about drug trade

By KATE LINTHICUM

MEXICO CITY — In a packed nightclub in Mexico City, hundreds of young people sang along as a band played a popular song nar-

rating the life of a foot soldier for the Sinaloa drug cartel.

I like to work / And if the order is to kill / You don’t question it.

And for those who misbehave / There’s no chance to explain / I throw them into

the grave.

Narcocorridos — or drug ballads — are more popular than ever in Mexico, where a new generation that came of age during the ongoing drug war has embraced songs

[See *Ballads*, A6]

Order envisions housing for vets

President Trump directs the Department of Veterans Affairs to create a center in West L.A. **NATION, A8**

And that’s the way it is for TV

Two of the three network evening newscasts are undergoing overhauls amid a sea change. **BUSINESS, A17**

L.A. rethinks homebuilding

Steel containers and 3D-printed homes may be part of the solution after devastating fires. **ENTERTAINMENT, E8-9**

Weather

Partly sunny, warm. L.A. Basin: 85/61. **B10**

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